

Self and Identity

Dr Yashpal Jogdand

AHUL261

Overview

- Introduction to the Self
- Sources of Self-Knowledge
- Self-Concept and Self-Esteem
- Self as: The Social Actor
- Self as: The Motivated Agent
- Self as: The Autobiographical Author


I
am
?

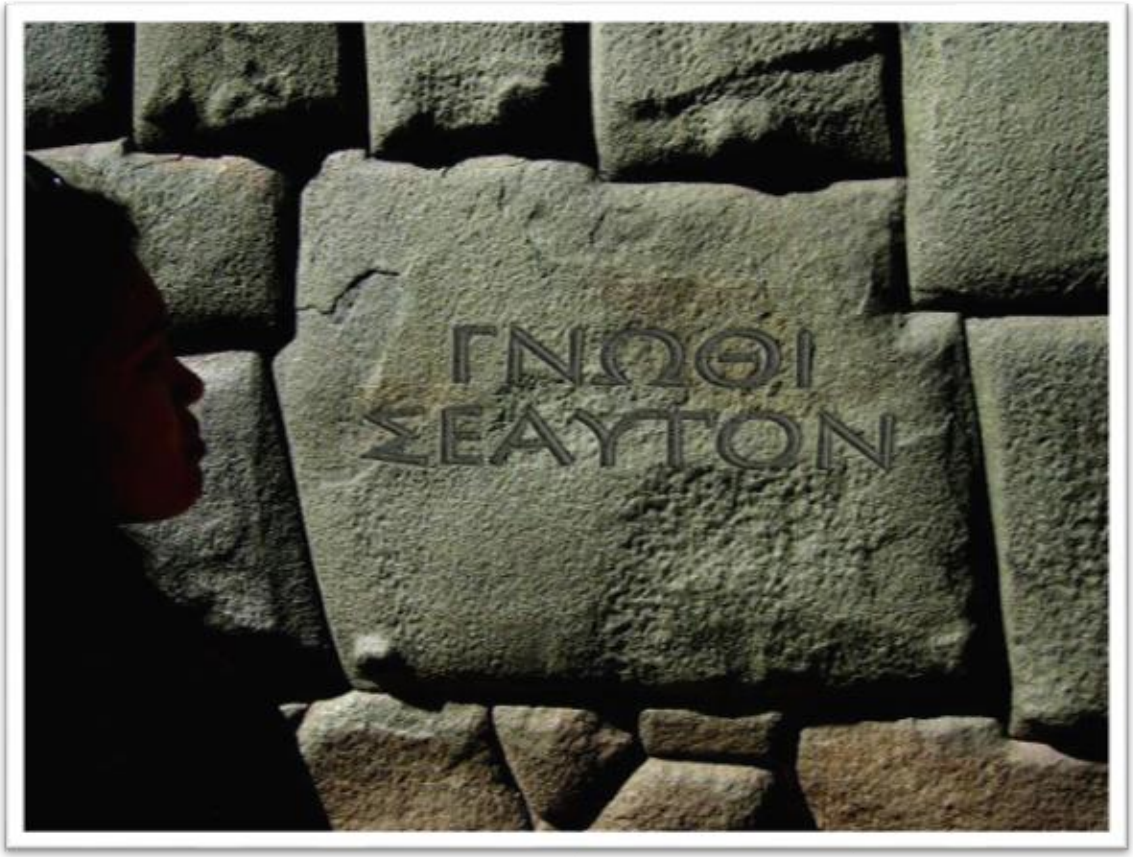
Do you notice following in your descriptions?

- You want to make a positive impression on others
- You mention positive aspects rather than negative ones
- Belonging to various social groups (family, caste/religion, nation, profession, peer group, etc) is an important part of who you are
- Can you imagine yourself writing the exactly same description about yourself after ten years?

This raises some important questions

- Is self a single, stable construct, or if ”who we are” differs depending on the social context?
- How self is related to various social groups?
- Why positive aspects of the self are valued over negative ones?
- What happens when positive aspects of the self are denied or ignored?
- Overall, what is self?

Introduction to the Self



“Know Thyself”

Introduction to the Self



The *I* and ***ME***

- *I see the BOARD* vs. *I see ME*

- The self as **I** is the agent of action, the subject

- It is not only the mental processes involved in knowing or our affection toward ourselves, but the ***awareness*** of this process of knowing and feeling.

- **ME** is the object of one's attention or knowledge of himself / herself

“I” – vs. – “Me”

- Self-as-subject
- Active process of experience
- Self-reflexiveness
- Self-awareness of ability to act & react
- Unique individuality

Self construction

- Self-as-object
- What know about self
- Self-descriptors
- Influenced by perceptions of other’s attitudes
- Internalised attitudes & values

Social construction



What is the SELF?

What is the self?

- There is no consensus on a conceptual definition

- Baumeister (1998) highlights three roots of selfhood

  - Reflexive Consciousness
  - Interpersonal Aspect
  - Executive Function

Reflexive Consciousness

- It is the subjective experience of “conscious attention turning back toward its own source and gradually constructing a concept of oneself” (Baumeister, 1998, p. 680)

- The self has unity and temporal continuity

Interpersonal & Intergroup Aspect

- The self is not only constructed subjectively, but it is affected by the social context as well

- Self is “vital for making interpersonal relationships and interactions possible” (Baumeister, 1998, p. 680).

- Self is derived from social group membership

Executive Function

- The self is the agent of all actions and the decision-maker (Baumeister, 1998)
- Volution, Agency, Responsibility
- It is the essential source of motivation to activate or inhibit actions

Sources of Self Knowledge:

How do we know ourselves?

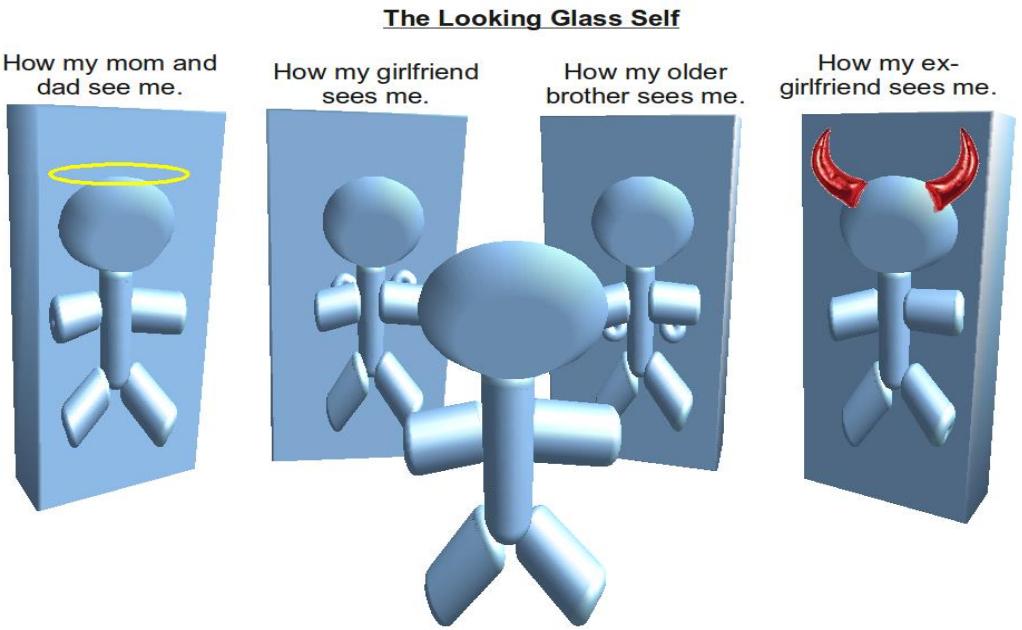
Who do you think you are?

- Charles Cooley (1902).

- <u>Looking glass self</u>

  – the idea that people learn about themselves by imagining how they appear to other.

- <u>Reflected Appraisals</u> – people come to think of themselves in the way they believe others think of them



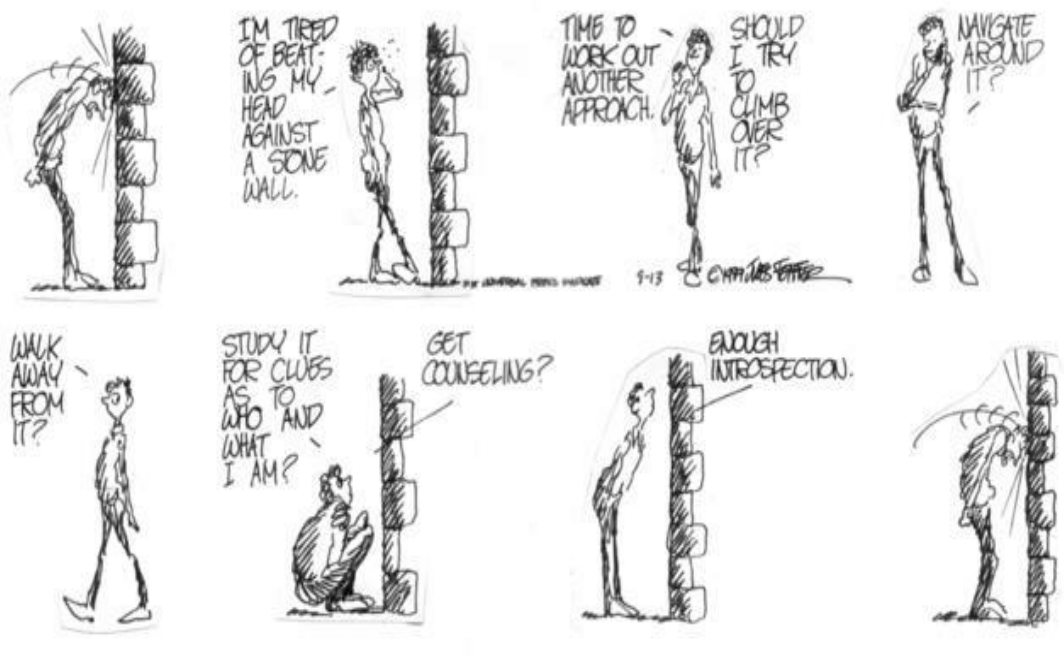
Introspection

- **Introspection:**

The process by which a person examines his/her mind and mental states.

- Privileged Access to our innermost thoughts and desires.

- Limitations:
  - Developmental critique – Children think their parents know them better than they know themselves.
  - Nisbett and Wilson (1971) showed that people do not really have much privileged access to their selves and do not realise how their minds work.



Social Comparison

- Leon Festinger (1954)
- Social Comparison: people learn about themselves by comparing themselves to others.
- *Upward social comparison*: comparing yourself to people better than you
- *Downward social comparison*: Comparing yourself to people worse off than you.



Self-esteem

Self-Concept vs. **Self-Esteem**



"**Self-concept** is the totality of the individual's thoughts and feelings with reference to himself as an object, which eventually explains himself, and the world at large, to himself." (Rosenberg, 1979, p. ix; Steele, 1988, p. 262)

"**Self-esteem** ... is a positive or negative attitude toward a particular object, namely, the self." (Rosenberg, 1965, p. 30)

1. I feel that I am a person of worth, at least on an equal basis with others.
2. I feel that I have a number of good qualities.
3. All in all, I am inclined to feel that I am a failure.*
4. I am able to do things as well as most other people.
5. I feel I do not have much to be proud of.*
6. I take a positive attitude toward myself.
7. On the whole, I am satisfied with myself.
8. I wish I could have more respect for myself.*
9. I certainly feel useless at times.*
10. At times I think I am no good at all.*

FIGURE 4.13 Measurement: The Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale

Each of the items with an asterisk is reverse-scored, and then an average of all ten items is computed so that higher numbers indicate greater self-esteem. (Source: Rosenberg, Morris. 1989. Society and the Adolescent Self-Image. Revised editions. Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press.).

Self-Esteem: Attitudes Toward Ourselves

For the most part, **self-esteem** has been conceptualized by social psychologists as the overall attitude people hold toward themselves. What kind of attitude do you have toward yourself—is it positive or negative? Is your attitude toward yourself stable, or do you think your self-esteem varies across time and contexts? New evidence has emerged showing that the average level of self-esteem in American high school students has been gradually increasing over time (Twenge & Campbell, 2008). Relative to students in the 1970s, students in 2006 report on average liking themselves considerably more.

Self-Esteem

- People's self-esteem seems to be responsive to life events. When we reflect on our achievements, self-esteem increases (Sedikides, Wildschut, Arndt, & Routledge, 2008).
- Likewise, considering our failures harms self esteem. For example, when people are reminded of the ways they fall short of their ideals, self-esteem decreases (Eisenstadt & Leippe, 1994).
- When people with low self-esteem experience negative feedback, their self-esteem suffers further declines (DeHart & Pelham, 2007).
- Being ostracized, excluded, or ignored by other people can be psychologically painful and cause reductions in self-esteem (DeWall et al., 2010; Williams, 2001)



Self and Culture

Culture and Self

- Markus and Kitayama (1991) proposed that Asians differ from Europeans and North Americans in how they think of themselves and how they seek to construct themselves in relation to others.

- Culture affects how the self is perceived.

  - ***Independent Self-Construal*—*in individualistic cultures, people develop a self-concept as separate from or independent of others.***

  - ***Interdependent Self-Construal*—*in collectivist cultures, people develop a self-concept in terms of one's connections or relationships with others.***

Culture and the Self

(Markus & Kitayama, 1991)

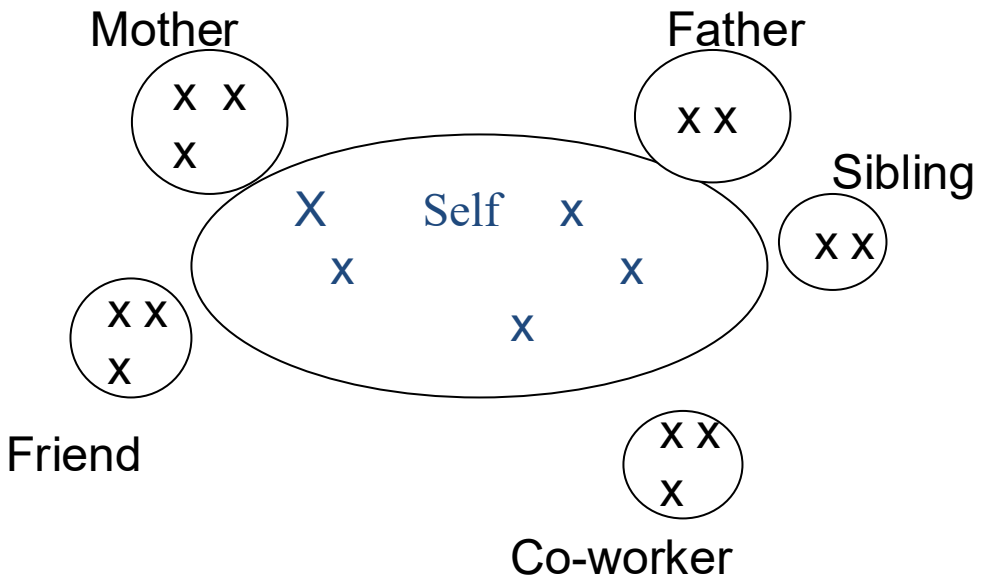
- **Individualist** culture is a culture in which the goals of the individual take precedence over the goals of the group.
- **Collectivist** culture is a culture in which the goals of the group take precedence over the goals of the individual.

- In Western cultures, the self is viewed as an independent, autonomous, separated being defined by a s unique repertoire of attributes, abilities, thoughts, and feelings
- In Eastern Cultures, the self is viewed as interdependent with others and is experienced as part of a social web

Culture and the Self - cont.

(Markus & Kitayama, 1991)

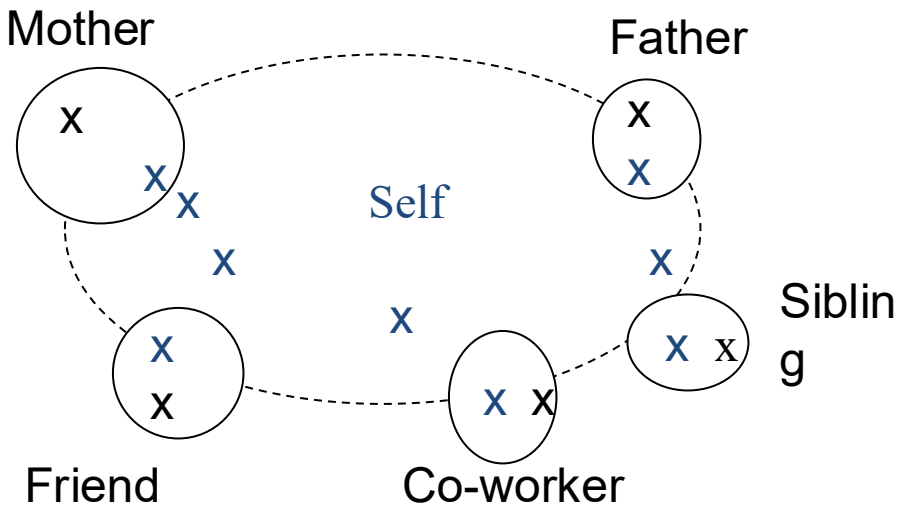
<u>Independent Self</u> In individualistic cultures, people develop a self-concept as separate from or independent of others.



Culture and the Self - cont.

(Markus & Kitayama, 1991)

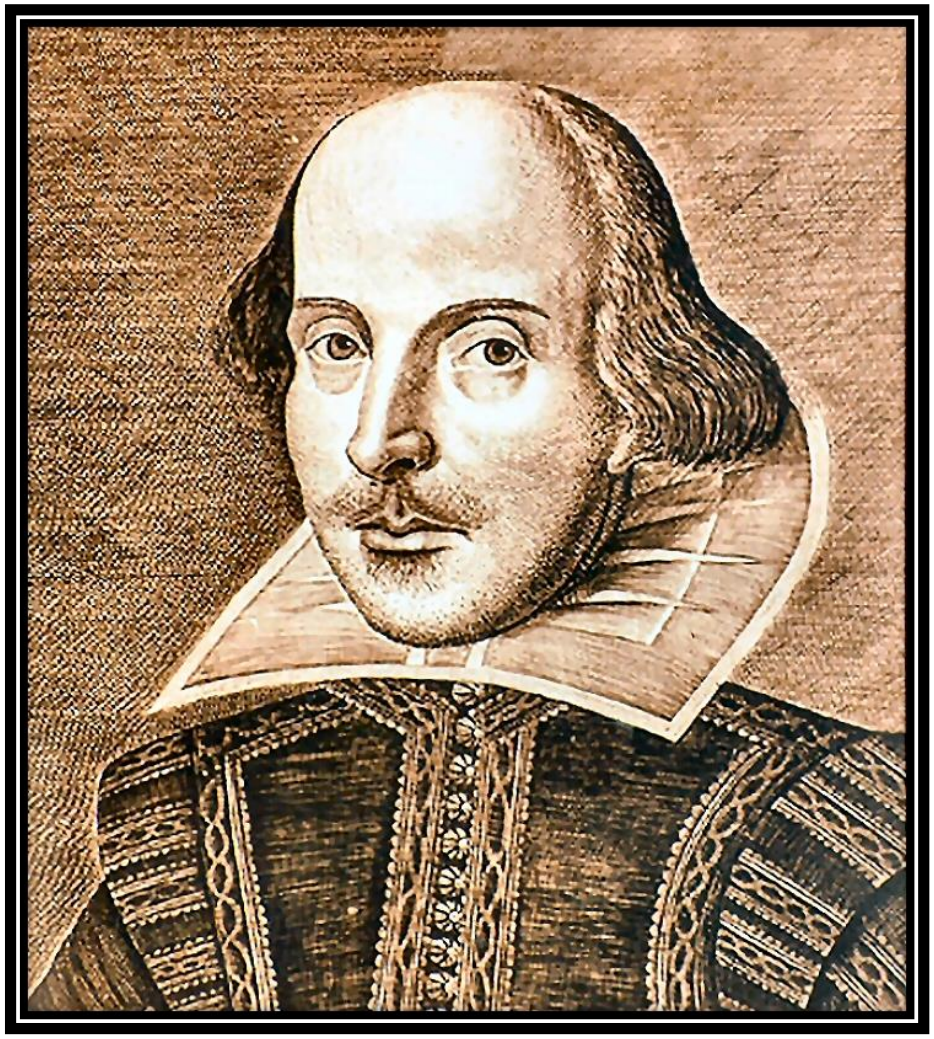
Interdependent Self **In collectivist cultures, people develop a self-concept in terms of one's connections or relationships with others.**



Overview

- **The Social Actor**
- The Motivated Agent
- The Autobiographical Author

The Social Actor



“All the world’s a stage, and all the men and women merely players.”

The role of Social Relations

We CANNOT develop psychologically without others – we are social beings in a very profound sense.

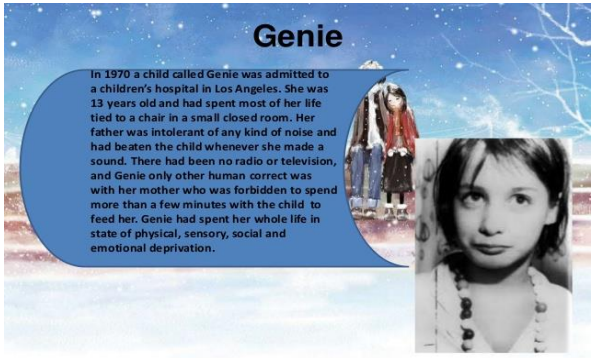
Evidence from:

- primate psychology

- wild children

- Social psychology





The Social Actor

Second Year

- Recognize self in mirror
- “Me” and “Mine”
- Shame/guilt



The role of Social Relations

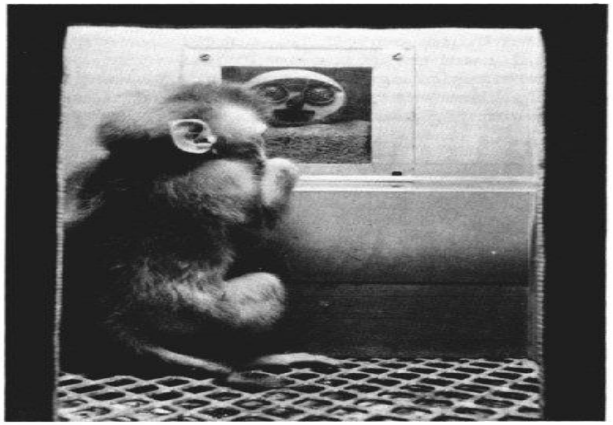


Figure 21. Visual exploration apparatus.

Harlow's Monkeys :
Chimps and apes brought up in isolation cannot recognise themselves in a mirror.

Apart from humans only chimps and apes will recognise their reflection in a mirror. But NOT when they had been raised in isolation – no recognition, no sense of self….

However after 3 months of social experience and physical contact with other chimpanzees – they will start to recognise themselves in a mirror. This demonstrates the vital important of others in the development of self-consciousness (Zazzo, 1975).

The Social Actor

Social Reputation = Central Traits + Social Roles



Conscientious Co-worker



Agreeable Friend



Extroverted Classmate

Overview

- The Social Actor
- **The Motivated Agent**
- The Autobiographical Author

The Motivated Agent

Theory of Mind:
Understanding that others' behavior is often motivated by inner desires and goals.

- Leads to understanding of oneself



The Motivated Agent

Age 5-to-7 Shift – Children become more intentional and systematic in their goal pursuit.



The Motivated Agent



Values + Life Goals → Identity

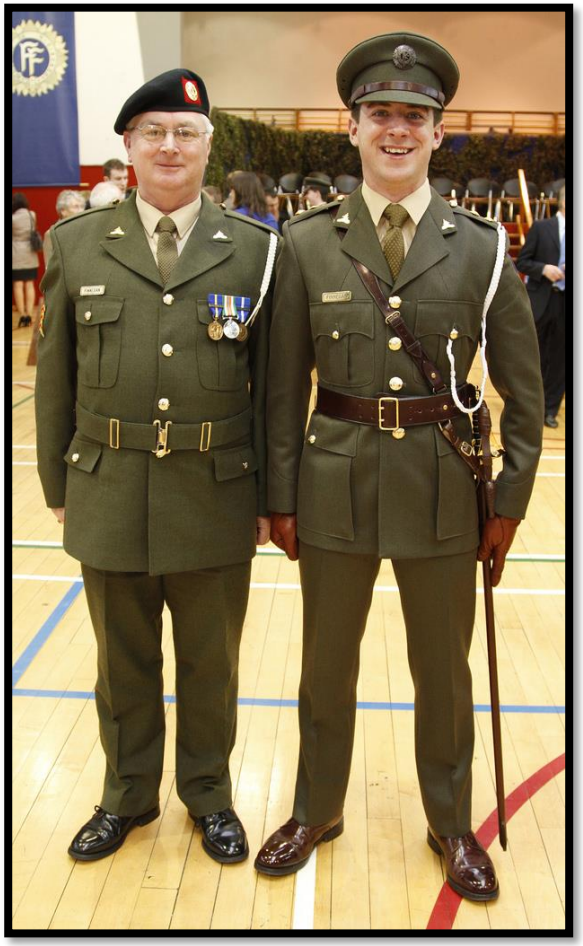
Overview

- The Social Actor
- The Motivated Agent
- **The Autobiographical Author**

The Autobiographical Author

Narrative Identity – Internalized and evolving story of the self.

- Reconstructs the past
- Anticipates the future
- Provides unity, meaning, and purpose



The Autobiographical Author

Autobiographical Reasoning - A narrator is able to derive substantive conclusions about the self from analyzing his or her own personal experiences.



The Autobiographical Author

Redemptive Narratives - Track the move from suffering to an enhanced status or state.







The Autobiographical Author



Photo Attribution



	Photo Credit: Smoochi https://www.flickr.com/photos/71661777@N00/2497190030/
Slide 1	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/2.0/
	Photo Credit: Mladifilozof http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Gnothi_seauton.jpg
Slide 3	http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/en:public_domain
	Photo Credit: Pix from the Field https://www.flickr.com/photos/25074624@N00/50607260/
Slide 4	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/2.0
	Photo Credit: Martin Droeshout http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Title_page_William_Shakespeare%27s_First_Folio_1623.jpg
Slide 6	http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Public_domain
	Photo Credit: Nongbri Family Pix https://www.flickr.com/photos/93295518@N00/1352505244/
Slide 7	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/2.0/
	Photo Credit: Joella Marano http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Charlie_Sheen_2012.jpg
Slide 8	http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/2.0/deed.en
	Photo Credit: Darcy Moore https://www.flickr.com/photos/28494098@N07/6800372289/
Slide 10	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/2.0/
	Photo Credit: www.audio-luci-store.it https://www.flickr.com/photos/65304769@N05/7403731050/
Slide 11	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/
	Photo Credit: cityyear https://www.flickr.com/photos/30745127@N07/10087828673/
Slide 12	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/2.0/
	Photo Credit: Irish Defence Forces https://www.flickr.com/photos/42787928@N06/5517230514/
Slide 14	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0/
	Photo Credit: lavishlylush https://www.flickr.com/photos/51413187@N05/4850727778/
Slide 15	https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/2.0/
	Photo Credit: Edgar Meritano http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Robert_Downey_Jr-2008.JPG
Slide 16	http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/deed.en
	Photo Credit: http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Actor_Robert_Downey_Jr._photographed_by_the_California_Department_of_Corrections.jpg
Slide 16	http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Public_domain
	Photo Credit: Antonio Litterio http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Stipula_fountain_pen.jpg
Slide 17	http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/deed.en